

1935–1945

## DREAM DRESSES

Surrealists tried to trick the subconscious into revealing itself by using methods influenced by the writings of Sigmund Freud: free association, dream analysis, and automatic writing. Aiming to achieve freedom from rationality, much of the output of this loose, Paris-centred group of artists, writers, and filmmakers had a dreamlike quality. Ordinary objects were taken out of their natural environments and plunged into new ones, creating a world “beyond realism”. Many surrealists were fascinated with disguise and fancy dress, and some were directly involved in the creation of fashionable clothes and imagery. Man Ray’s fashion and advertising photographs were published in *Vogue* and *Harper’s Bazaar*. Salvador Dali, Alberto Giacometti, Meret Oppenheim, and Jean Cocteau all collaborated with Elsa Schiaparelli on designs of clothes and accessories. Startling juxtapositions and the use of motifs from other contexts could be found in the work of several couturiers in the late 1930s and early 1940s, and surrealism continues to influence fashion today.

## SURREALIST ACCESSORIES

Handbags and hats in particular lent themselves to the surrealist treatment, as they did not have to fit to the human body. These telephone and champagne bucket bags were made by Anne Marie of Paris, a shop based in the Parisian Hotel Meurice in the late 1940s. Possibly the most famous surrealist accessory was a hat in the form of a high-heeled shoe turned upside down. It was based on a sketch by Salvador Dali and featured in Elsa Schiaparelli’s 1937–38 Fall/Winter collection.



1939

**Masks** Jean Cocteau designed the fabric for this dress by US-based Charles James, incorporating portraits of himself and his lover – actor Jean Marais. Cocteau denied the influence of surrealism on his work, but his films, in particular, have surrealist qualities.



1937

**Lobster** Salvador Dali had incorporated lobsters into his work a few years prior to his collaboration with French designer Schiaparelli. Cecil Beaton photographed Wallis Simpson in one of the few copies of this dress, not long before her marriage to the Duke of Windsor.



**Horses** Lounging pyjamas were in some ways the successors of the tea gown and could be worn for receiving guests at home. The rearing horses give a fantasy flourish to this witty example by the American designer Elizabeth Hawes.